

then both God and Satan must have a lively interest in its fortunes. To approach the textual criticism of the NT without taking due account of that interest is to act irresponsibly.

Most damage done by 200 AD

It is generally agreed that most significant variants existed by the end of the second century. “The overwhelming majority of readings were created before the year 200”, affirmed Colwell.¹ “It is no less true to fact than paradoxical in sound that the worst corruptions to which the New Testament has ever been subjected, originated within a hundred years after it was composed”, said Scrivener decades before.² Kilpatrick commented on the evidence of the earliest Papyri.

Let us take our two manuscripts of about this date [AD 200] which contain parts of John, the Chester Beatty Papyrus and the Bodmer Papyrus. They are together extant for about seventy verses. Over these seventy verses they differ some seventy-three times apart from mistakes.

Further in the Bodmer Papyrus the original scribe has frequently corrected what he first wrote. At some places he is correcting his own mistakes but at others he substitutes one form of phrasing for another. At about seventy-five of these substitutions both alternatives are known from other manuscripts independently. The scribe is in fact replacing one variant reading by another at some seventy places so that we may conclude that already in his day there was variation at these points.³

The Bodmer papyrus is P⁶⁶, and what Kilpatrick does not tell you is that in those 75 places the scribe was alternating between Byzantine and Alexandrian readings: sometimes he started with a Byzantine reading and then changed it to an Alexandrian and sometimes he did the opposite. He obviously had such exemplars before him, which means that the Byzantine Text was already in existence in the year 200!

¹ E.C. Colwell, “The Origin of Texttypes of New Testament Manuscripts”, *Early Christian Origins*, ed. Allen Wikgren (Chicago: Quadrangle Books, 1961), p. 138.

² F.H.A. Scrivener, *A Plain Introduction to the Criticism of the New Testament*, fourth edition edited by E. Miller (2 Vols.; London: George Bell and Sons, 1894), II, 264.

³ G.D. Kilpatrick, “The Transmission of the New Testament and its Reliability”, *The Bible Translator*, IX (July, 1958), 128-29.